

Morning Edition

Monday, 10 August 2026

Ten stories from the ocean governance, hydrospatial science, and blue economy beat — filtered for what actually touches your work.

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OCEAN GOVERNANCE

The High Seas Treaty Enters Its Working Phase

BBNJ has been in force since January, which means the two-thirds of the ocean that sits beyond national jurisdiction now has a legal architecture for the first time. That is the frame HARMONiSE has to slot into. Whatever spatial data infrastructure Seychelles builds for its own EEZ now sits next to a parallel high-seas regime with its own area-based management tools,

environmental impact assessment rules, and benefit-sharing obligations.

The agreement has cleared ratification with 83 parties and 145 signatories. The real work has shifted to the Preparatory Commission, which is negotiating how the first Conference of the Parties will function: how area-based management proposals get submitted and reviewed, and how the treaty's technical and scientific body will operate once it exists.

For a state whose blue economy ambitions extend past its own EEZ into the wider Western Indian Ocean, the design choices being locked in at these PrepCom sessions decide whether a small state can realistically table an ABMT proposal, or whether the process ends up dominated by states that already have high-seas science capacity. Worth tracking as the PrepCom reports circulate.

sdg.iisd.org — [BBNJ Agreement enters into force](#)

⚡ ACTIONABLE — REGISTRATION OPEN

02 / HYDROSPATIAL SCIENCE

28.7% of the Seafloor Is Mapped — and Kuala Lumpur Wants Your Data

This is the number the Ocean Mapping Hub's advocacy case rests on. Under a third of the global ocean floor has modern bathymetric coverage, and Seabed 2030 just added almost five million square kilometres in a year, still short of pace for the 2030 target. Every satellite-derived bathymetry dataset Seychelles or its neighbours contribute is coverage the Nippon Foundation-GEBCO project cannot buy any other way.

The regional detail matters more than the global one. The ROPME Sea Area's coverage tripled in a year, from roughly 6.4% to 20.5%, helped by a nearly 300,000 square kilometre SDB contribution from Greenwater Foundation spanning 20 nations. First-time national submissions this year came from Malaysia, Morocco, Papua New Guinea, and Saudi Arabia — exactly the profile of contributor Seychelles should be matching.

The Indo-Pacific Ocean Mapping Meeting & Data Sprint runs in Kuala Lumpur, 20 to 22 October.

Registration is open now, and it is a concrete venue to either contribute Seychelles SDB data or scope a national submission.

SIDS EQUITY & CLIMATE FINANCE

SIDS Get a Sliver of the Climate Finance They're Owed

64%

OF SIDS OCEAN-RELATED CLIMATE COMMITMENTS DEPEND ON EXTERNAL SUPPORT THAT MOSTLY ISN'T ARRIVING

This is evidence for the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument, running in the direction that hits most SIDS but not the one that hits Seychelles specifically. Most small island states are locked out of climate finance because funders treat them as too small and too fragmented to underwrite efficiently. Seychelles gets the opposite penalty: its GNI per capita disqualifies it from concessional finance altogether, despite carrying the same ocean exposure as its poorer neighbours.

A new Back to Blue report puts numbers on the general gap. SIDS contribute under 1% of global emissions but absorb outsized climate risk

through an ocean that makes up 70% of their biosphere — and 64% of their ocean-related climate commitments depend on external support that isn't showing up at the scale needed.

Useful citation for the next funding pitch, or a Shorelines piece arguing that "high income" is the wrong proxy for climate vulnerability.

[unctad.org](https://unctad.org/en/PublicationsLibrary/ClimateFinanceforSIDS.pdf) — [Climate finance for SIDS is shockingly low](https://unctad.org/en/PublicationsLibrary/ClimateFinanceforSIDS.pdf)

03 / BLUE ECONOMY — SEYCHELLES

Nineteen Agreements, One Blue Bond, and the Case Study Writes Itself

This one is home turf. Prime Minister Modi's June state visit to Seychelles produced nineteen bilateral outcomes across development finance, maritime cooperation, and infrastructure, landing on top of a sovereign blue bond that is now seven years into funding stock assessments, catch monitoring, and traceability systems for artisanal fisheries.

Seychelles still runs roughly 80% of the Western Indian Ocean's tuna catch through Port Victoria, in the world's second-largest tuna basin at about 20% of global production. That is the leverage point: a blue economy built on one dominant, well-monitored fishery, with donor attention now stacking a second layer of finance on top of the first.

Worth revisiting for Shorelines as the counter-example to reach for when the High-Income SIDS Paradox argument needs a "here's what capital actually does when it shows up" case, rather than the usual absence-of-capital framing.

cnbcafrica.com — [Seychelles 2026/2027: finance, infrastructure, blue economy](#)

\$ TOPIC --GEOAI --OCEAN

[04] GeoAI's Market Number Is Small. The Capability Gap Behind It Isn't.

> The USD 172 million 2026 figure for AI-driven geospatial analytics is almost beside the point. What matters for HARMONiSE is that GeoAI research is converging fast on the exact stack the Ocean Mapping Hub needs: satellite-derived bathymetry, Argo network fusion, and now conversational

interfaces like OceanAI sitting on top of oceanographic reanalysis products.

> The direction of travel in the literature is toward explainability and adaptability, not raw prediction accuracy alone – the right emphasis for anything Seychelles would need to defend in front of a funder or a regional fisheries body. A black-box bathymetry model is a hard sell to IOC-UNESCO. An explainable one is a grant application.

> Track the *Remote Sensing* special issue on GeoAI and EO big data for citable methods when HARMONiSE's technical annex needs backing.

[sciencedirect.com – GeoAI: beyond mapping earth and cities](https://www.sciencedirect.com/journal/Remote%20Sensing/specialissue/S0926641020300000)

06 · OCEAN GOVERNANCE — PEER-REVIEWED

The Governance Gap Under BBNJ Has a Name Now

A paper in *Frontiers in Marine Science* this year gives precise language to a problem SHORE Institute has been circling for a while: high seas MPA decision-making sits inside a "layered and dispersed institutional environment," where regional fisheries bodies differ wildly in capacity, timelines, and whether

marine biodiversity conservation is even part of their mandate.

That is the implementation gap BBNJ was meant to close and hasn't yet, because the treaty's area-based management tool process still has to negotiate around existing regional fisheries management organisations rather than override them. For a small state trying to table a high seas ABMT proposal, that means working out which of several overlapping bodies actually has to sign off before a Seychelles proposal goes anywhere.

Cite directly if the next Shorelines piece needs a peer-reviewed source for: the high seas treaty entering into force did not, by itself, fix the coordination problem. – Frontiers in Marine Science, "High seas marine protected areas under the BBNJ agreement: implementation gaps and governance pathways," 2026.

[frontiersin.org — full paper](https://frontiersin.org/fullpaper)

07 • DATA SOVEREIGNTY

Whose Ocean Data Is It

“The Third World Ocean Assessment calls for greater recognition of Indigenous knowledge in ocean governance, drawing on nearly 600 experts from 86 countries.”

Data sovereignty is one of the standing focus areas, and this is the UN's clearest recent statement of it applied to the ocean rather than land. Ocean Networks

Canada's parallel work on Indigenous ocean data sovereignty, explicitly framed as "decolonizing data," is a workable template for what HARMONiSE's own data governance protocols should look like whenever SHORE Institute works with community or artisanal fisher data in Seychelles.

The open question the Assessment doesn't answer: who holds veto rights over spatial data collected in someone else's traditional fishing grounds, and whether a hydrospatial observatory needs a data sovereignty policy before its first survey, not after.

[staradvertiser.com — UN report highlights Indigenous knowledge in ocean governance](https://staradvertiser.com/2023/09/07/un-report-highlights-indigenous-knowledge-in-ocean-governance/)

 ACTIONABLE — DEADLINES BELOW

08

FUNDING & OPPORTUNITIES

Three Ocean Funding Windows Close Between Now and October

Not background reading, this one is a to-do list. Pure Ocean's call for projects opens 1 September with Phase 1 applications open through 1 October. The

Weeden Foundation's marine conservation grants, USD 10,000 to 30,000, have returning grantees on a 4 September full-proposal deadline. IOOS's USD 7.5 million Ocean Technology Transition programme has already closed for new applications but announces selections in September — worth watching for partnership signals even without a live window.

None of these fund HARMONiSE outright, but Pure Ocean and Weeden are both plausible seed or bridge funding for a discrete Ocean Mapping Hub pilot, and both have proposal cycles short enough to turn around before year end.

pure-ocean.org — [Call for projects 2026](#)

A Pliocene Current Shift Gets a Fresh Read

Not urgent, but the kind of paper worth knowing exists. New *Nature Geoscience* research traces how the Southern Ocean's subtropical front moved north during the late Pliocene, cutting salt transport by the Agulhas Leakage — the

current system that connects the Indian and Atlantic Oceans directly off southern Africa.

The Agulhas system sits upstream of everything the Western Indian Ocean does hydrographically,

including the water masses
Seychelles sits in. A paleoclimate
paper on how that current
responded to a warmer climate
state is a useful long-baseline
reference point for anything
SHORE Institute eventually has to

say about projected changes to
regional circulation.

Filed for the hydrosatial science
reading list rather than immediate
action, but worth having on hand
the next time a funder asks what's
known about regional circulation
risk.

[nature.com/ngeo](https://www.nature.com/ngeo) — [browse articles](#)

 **ACTIONABLE — CLOSES 31 AUGUST**

— **X** —

UN OCEAN DECADE

The Ocean Decade's Current Call Closes August 31

Three weeks out. Call for Decade Actions No. 11/2026 is open until 31 August, built around the Barcelona Statement priorities, and it explicitly includes travel support to enable diverse participation — including small island states — at the 2027 Ocean Decade Conference.

This is a live avenue to get SHORE Institute or the Ocean Mapping Hub formally endorsed as a UN Ocean Decade Action, which carries more weight with

fundes than unaffiliated NGO status, and the travel support line is aimed squarely at closing the participation gap for under-resourced delegations.

Endorsement applications go through the Ocean Decade website before the 31 August close.

oceandecade.org — Call for Decade Actions

Shorelines

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